NINJAS STEM FOUNDATION

Volunteer & Mentor Guidelines

Role assignment, student safety, educational integrity, and records

Policy ID	Approval status	Effective date
NSF-CP-03	Proposed; not adopted	To be established

1. Purpose and who is covered

These Guidelines govern NSF adult and youth volunteers who assist competitive robotics teams, workshops, mentoring, outreach events, website/media projects, fundraising support, and administration. They supplement the Foundation's Youth Protection & Safety Policy, Code of Conduct, Student Participation Policy, applicable competition rules, and approved role descriptions.

Volunteer service is not a corporate office, directorship, corporate membership, independent purchasing authority, or guarantee that the volunteer's child will receive admission, a particular role, or renewal.

2. Role onboarding and qualifications

An NSF adult lead shall identify the volunteer's scope, supervisor, expected duration, availability, access needs, training, safeguarding requirements, and any required venue or competition credentials. No person shall start a role that requires clearance or training before those requirements are met.

Where relevant, adult volunteers may be asked to provide general skills or experience, references, training acknowledgments and conflict disclosures. NSF should collect only information reasonably needed for the role and store it securely.

Youth volunteers shall participate in age-appropriate educational roles under suitable adult supervision. Neither adult nor youth volunteer status automatically authorizes unsupervised access to minors.

3. Educational conduct and student ownership

Adult mentors teach principles, ask questions, supervise safe practice, and provide feedback without taking control of student-owned competition work. Students must understand and create their own designs, code, engineering records and strategies as required by applicable competition policies.

When reviewing student deliverables, volunteers use age-appropriate, disclosed learning objectives. Student mistakes should be treated as learning opportunities. Public-facing content is reviewed for factual accuracy and readiness before publication. Adults resolve disagreements with one another, not through contradictory student instructions.

4. Safeguarding and appropriate boundaries

Volunteers comply with the Youth Protection & Safety Policy, including observable interaction, adult screening where applicable, approved communication channels, transportation rules, home-practice safeguards, tools, photography, and reporting.

Do not engage in secret or private adult–minor communications outside approved channels; favor group messages or messages with an authorized adult/parent included. Do not contact or meet students privately through a role at NSF. Physical, verbal, emotional, sexual or online misconduct is prohibited.

Immediate danger goes to emergency services. Suspected child abuse or neglect must be reported under applicable law without waiting for an NSF investigation or approval.

5. Attendance, commitments, and escalation

Volunteers should accept only realistic commitments, notify the supervisor promptly of cancellations or missed deadlines, and arrange an appropriate handoff for assigned work. No volunteer should promise a host, sponsor, or parent that another NSF volunteer will perform work without confirmation.

A mentor may stop unsafe activity immediately and must promptly inform the designated responsible adult. Substantive concerns, potential conflicts, harassment or suspected misuse of resources are reported through the established route and an alternate unconflicted route when needed.

6. Official communications and external representations

Only authorized persons may submit official grant or host applications, solicit funds in NSF's name, promise publicity, issue donation acknowledgments, make organizational statements, or sign agreements. A student's participation in drafting an email or presentation is educational and does not itself authorize external commitment.

Use accurate names, approved logos, current program descriptions, verified events and supported impact numbers. Do not imply that an independent mentored team is NSF-operated, or that an organization is an ongoing partner merely because a proposal was sent.

7. Property, expenses, records and intellectual property

Foundation property may be used only for an authorized purpose, maintained safely, and returned to its assigned custodian. Reimbursements require prior authorization and supporting records; volunteer time does not independently establish a financial claim.

Store work products and NSF-related correspondence in designated shared repositories. Protect student and donor information, intellectual property, credentials, and confidential inquiries. Student-generated work and third-party materials are not automatically assigned to the Foundation by volunteering; rights must be addressed separately where necessary.

8. Conflicts, impartiality and conduct

Volunteers disclose material interests in vendors, reimbursements, admissions, media use or decisions affecting their own children. Disclosed conflicts are handled according to the relevant approval process. Donating funds or time shall not create a preference in student selection.

Volunteers must not retaliate for lawful good-faith concerns. An unresolved allegation is not automatically proof of wrongdoing, and legitimate criticism of governance is not itself a conduct violation. The applicable process differs for volunteer assignment, student enrollment, corporate office, and directorship.

9. Ending a role and acknowledgment

A volunteer may notify the program lead of resignation or changed availability. NSF may end or reassign an operational volunteer engagement through an appropriately authorized process. This does not automatically end any separately held Board or officer position or a child's participation.

Before departure, return materials and accounts, preserve organizational records, disclose pending commitments, and transfer assigned work. The relevant official shall confirm completion, without requesting unrelated personal passwords. Volunteers shall receive and acknowledge the operative policies appropriate to their actual role.